Nonetheless, it gives an idea of the Indian world view during the Iron Age. The name Mahabharata is itself interesting as it can be read to mean ‘Greater India’. This would make sense for an epic that claims to tell the story involving all the clans of the subcontinent. The text itself explains the name in terms of a primordial Emperor Bharata who is said to have conquered the whole country (but plays no important role in the central plot). The epic is therefore told as a history of the Bharata people. Since there is no independent evidence of an all-conquering Emperor Bharata, one wonders if this is an echo of the powerful Bharata tribe mentioned in the Rig Veda. Did Sudas’s victory against the ten tribes create a dream of civilizational nationhood that gets echoed over the millennia?

There are interesting parallels with the Chinese view of civilizational nationhood. Long before the country was united into an empire by Qin Shi Huangdi in the third century BC, there was a strongly held belief that the country had once been united under the revered ‘Yellow Emperor’ and his four successors. [7] There is noarchaeological evidence to support such a grand empire but it has been a very powerful idea throughout Chinese history. Indeed, it is embedded in the way China views itself even today.

The notion of a civilizational nation is not a simple one. It has meant different things to different people at different points in time. The Partition of India in 1947, for instance, was partly due to a fundamental divergence in views about the nature of India’s civilizational nationhood. Still, it is important to recognize how Bronze Age ideas, honed in the Iron Age, gave shape to the way people have viewed themselves ever since.

The epics, furthermore, suggest a shift of political power to the eastern Gangetic plains during the Iron Age. It is more obvious in the Ramayana as the kingdom of Ayodhya is itself in the east. In the Mahabharata, most of the action takes place near Delhi in the north-west but, even here, we are told of the powerful kingdom ruled by Jarasandha in Magadh (modern Bihar). Indeed, even Krishna was forced to shift his people from Mathura to Gujarat because of the repeated raids of the Magadhan army. As we shall see, the rise of Magadh would have a pivotal role in later Indian history. So, why was Magadh so successful?